TKC Volume One — The World Dossier

Oct 23, 2026 · @Dany

How this volume works

Volume One is about the world: the history, institutions, beliefs and places that produced Eden's story. The people and the chapters belong to Volume Two. When a fact about the world matters to one particular person, this volume points to her dossier instead of working it out here.

The world parts (VI through XI) come first in this doc because you need the whole world in hand before you build chapters. They're written from your source files, your Final Rulings and the rulings you made in the calibration doc. Parts I through V, the scripture research, will be rewritten from the old Companion next and slot in ahead of them when the volume is assembled.

Reading the labels

Anything established by your files carries a source tag and no label. Everything else is labeled at the start of the sentence or paragraph it governs.

Tag	Source
TL	Timeline Updated
TR	The Covenant Trials Updated
TR-orig	The original Covenant Trials file. Used only where the updated file is silent, and superseded wherever they disagree.
DOM	The Dominions Update
MEN	Men in the Covenant Empire
CR	The Crownward
DR3	Draft Three (Chapter One so far)
WR	Writing Rules
FR 0–44	Final Rulings, by number

Tag	Source
AM	Audit Master (the old Companion)
Ruling	A ruling you made in the calibration doc on October 23

Label	Meaning
RESEARCH	Outside fact, with a source
INTERPRETATION	A reading of the material, offered as a reading
CONTESTED	A real scholarly or theological dispute
INFERENCE	A conclusion drawn from your files that they don't state
POSSIBLE	An idea worth considering. Not canon.
OPEN QUESTION	Something you still have to decide
CONFLICT	Two of your sources disagree
SUPERSEDED	Older material that no longer controls
DECIDED	A call you handed to me. Treated as canon until you overrule it.

Every part closes with working questions, and each one gets real room on the page. Bracketed design notes mark places where a visual would carry the information better than prose. Nothing here is designed yet. The doc exports to Word or PDF from its menu if you want a plain printed copy before the designed version exists.

Part VI. The Fall of the United States

The United States became the Covenant Empire of America over about eighteen years. It started with a stadium sermon in 2033 and ended in 2051, when the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were written into the constitution as the three branches of government. Almost every step went through a vote, a referendum or an agreement (TL). Nobody in Eden's lifetime remembers the country before. The oldest person in her cast was born around 2035, into its last few years.

VI.1 The timeline

Year	Event	Source
2025–2031	The Fracture Years. A contested election leaves two men claiming the presidency at once. Automated labor wipes out forty percent of working-class jobs. Domestic attacks on federal buildings go uncontained, and a climate disaster makes the Gulf Coast uninhabitable. Faith in federal institutions collapses, and church attendance triples.	TL
2031	Evangelical megachurches, conservative political action groups and private militias organize as the Covenant Coalition. Their platform: "America was great when it was godly. Return to God. Return to greatness." They run candidates at every level of government at once.	TL
2033	Elias Vane, a little-known Georgia preacher, preaches *Thy Kingdom Come* for six hours to 400,000 people at The Gathering House, the former Mercedes-Benz Stadium in Atlanta. Every Coalition network carries it live.	TL
2035	Vane wins a Senate seat from Georgia. Within eighteen months he effectively controls the legislative agenda.	TL
c. 2035	Celeste Parish born	INFERENCE from TL
2039	California, Oregon and New York attempt to secede. The Coalition-controlled federal government calls it treason, and a two-year standoff follows.	TL
2041	The Partition Agreement brings the three states back with "regional autonomy." The autonomy is dismantled about four years later. Vane authors the Restoration Act, which passes Congress narrowly, under conditions later described as coercion.	TL

Year	Event	Source
2043	Vane declares the United States dissolved and reborn as the Covenant Empire of America. He takes the title First Elector. The Crownward is formally established over Washington, D.C.	TL, CR
2044	The Dominion Act reorganizes the states into Twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate. Atlanta becomes Aurelia, seat of the Dominion of Aurem.	TL
2048	Elias Vane, 52, marries Sera Callum, 28, a Vowed woman and Temple scholar. It's the first Anointed marriage.	TL
2051	The Triune Rule makes the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast the three constitutional governing bodies.	TL
2054	Vane becomes Emperor by a referendum that returns 94 percent approval. He founds the House of Vane.	TL
2058	The Commonwife quota system is piloted in Red Earth.	DOM
2061	Elias Vane dies of heart failure at 65. The Temple canonizes him within the year. His face goes on the currency, and his sermon becomes required curriculum in every Dominion school. The same year, Elias's elder child, the rightful successor and Dorian's parent, is removed.	TL, FR 35–36
2062	Crest Vane takes the throne at 34. The Commonwife quotas are introduced, and the Ungoverned are designated criminal.	TL
2065	The first Covenant Trials	TL
2077	Azrael Vane born	TL
2079	Judah Vane born	TL
2085	Crest dies mid-cycle. Dorian takes the throne at 40, and that year's Trial is cancelled.	TL, FR 39

Year	Event	Source
2098	Azrael, 21, finds a ledger in the east wing archive	TL
2100	Azrael is officially declared dead. The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent vanish the same week.	TL
2104	The 39th Covenant Trial	TL

CONFLICT: The timeline introduces the Commonwife quotas under Crest in 2062, and the Dominions file says Red Earth piloted them in 2058. INFERENCE: Both can be true if the 2058 pilot ran under Elias in one Dominion and Crest took it Empire-wide in 2062.

[DESIGN NOTE: This could become a two-page horizontal timeline, with the Fracture Years shaded as one band and the four rulers marked along the bottom.]

VI.2 How the Empire tells it, and what the record shows

Everyone in Eden's world learned the left column in school. Where a character sits between the two columns says a lot about who she is. The Empire's phrasing is also what people would actually say out loud, so it's the version to use in dialogue (AM).

What the Empire calls it	What happened
The Fracture Years, which God ended	Six years of overlapping disasters that a well-organized coalition was ready to inherit
The Restoration	A 400-page law that made rights conditional, passed under coercion nobody had to name
Regional autonomy, granted in mercy	A four-year holding pattern for three states that tried to leave, dismantled once the leverage was gone
Public mandate, 94 percent	A referendum controlled tightly enough to produce the number it wanted
Reorganized for accuracy and unity	The press became a branch of government
Citizenship clarified through covenant	A woman's legal standing became dependent on whether a man has married her

What the Empire calls it	What happened
A celebration of the Empire's finest women	A televised selection that produces one Anointed Wife a year, and eleven women married down the elite ladder (FR 19)
A sudden medical event	The phrase the Empire uses for Azrael in 2100 and for Petra in 2104

[DESIGN NOTE: Side-by-side comparison here: OFFICIAL VERSION / LIVED REALITY.]

VI.3 The Restoration Act

The Restoration Act of 2041 is the legal root of almost everything in Eden's life. The timeline gives four things it did (TL).

- **Rights become conditional.** They depend on standing, compliance and designation.
- **Marriage becomes a legal and theological designation.** The Binding, the Commonwife quota and the Anointed marriage all descend from this line.
- **Women's citizenship is reclassified as dependent on marital status.** This is why Unbound is a legal category with a file and not a description of someone's life.
- **The press is "reorganized for accuracy and unity."** Ten years later the same apparatus is a branch of government, and today it controls forty percent of a Covenant Daughter's score.

The act passed Congress, so the Empire's founding argument is that nothing illegal happened (TL).

OPEN QUESTION: What does the Act's preamble say? You'll want the actual wording for any scene where a character quotes the Restoration.

VI.4 Living memory

Nobody in the cast lived through the Fall as an adult. What survives comes down through grandmothers and through the House of Vane's own documents.

Celeste Parish (TL). She was about nine in 2044 and remembers the renaming of Atlanta. She remembers her own grandmother crying when they changed the signs. She watched the Empire take her mother's identity through a Commonwife marriage, then raised Miriam alone under Unbound designation rather than let it happen again. The real name of the city is the last thing she says to Eden before the Crownward. (Volume Two, Celeste.)

Sera Montoya's grandmother (TR). She was at the last protest before the Partition Agreement ended Pacific's resistance in 2041. She tells it to Sera as a warning, not a hero story: the difference between impact and loss is knowing when and how. (Volume Two, Sera.)

Pacific's generations (DOM). The people who remember trying to leave raised children who grew up with parents who'd tried and failed. Their grandchildren grew up knowing the story. The Empire still checks every Pacific girl's Designation for signs that the secession story survived in her.

Zara Voss's grandmother (TR). She has a real name the desert knows and the Empire doesn't. She raised Zara in Sable Reach and in the desert beyond it. (Volume Two, Zara.)

The House of Vane (TL, FR 35–44). The family keeps documents instead of grandmothers' stories, and those documents are the most dangerous things in the Crownward. See VI.5.

VI.5 Founder files

Elias Vane (c. 1996–2061). A relatively unknown Georgia preacher until the 2033 sermon (TL). His dates put his birth around 1996 (INFERENCE, from his ages in 2048, 2054 and 2061). He won his Senate seat in 2035, authored the Restoration Act in 2041, became First Elector in 2043 and Emperor in 2054, and died in 2061. The Temple canonized him within a year. His face is on the currency, and *Thy Kingdom Come* is required curriculum in every Dominion school. The Temple teaches that God chose him specifically to restore the nation and that his descendants carry that anointing forward (CR).

INTERPRETATION: The old Companion's reading of his method still holds. He never took anything until refusing him would cost more than giving in. He ran candidates everywhere, made himself the man every faction needed, outlasted the secession instead of winning it, and wrote the law himself (AM).

Sera Callum Vane. A Vowed woman and Temple scholar who married Elias in 2048, when she was 28. She became the most powerful woman in the Empire's history while appearing entirely devoted to her husband. She wrote most of his domestic policy, and no official record says so (TL). Her marriage is the template for the Covenant Trials.

CONFLICT: The timeline says she came from "the Northern Dominion." None of the Twelve Dominions has that name.

Crest Vane (Emperor 2062–2085). Elias's son. He took the throne at 34, so he was born around 2028, twenty years before his father's Anointed marriage (INFERENCE). He's cold and procedural. He manages people instead of inspiring them, and under him the Empire

grows both more efficient and more brutal (TL). He introduced the Commonwife quotas, criminalized the Ungoverned and created the Trials. His claim came through survivorship, not birth order (FR 35, 39). He knew about his elder sibling's removal, didn't arrange it and didn't prevent it (FR 37). The one thing he did was preserve the documents, leaving them where the east wing archive would someday be inventoried (FR 40).

The removed heir. Elias's elder child, and the rightful successor. Removed in 2061, when Dorian was still a child (FR 35–36).

Dorian Vane (Emperor since 2085). The removed heir's son. He took the throne at 40 and is 59 in 2104 (TL, Ruling). He was spared because a child's claim can be supervised. Removing him would have needed a public reason, while raising him inside the house needed none (FR 38). He has known since 2061 that the documents name Elias (FR 44). Under him the Broadcast became genuinely sophisticated, and the Trials became the most-watched event of the year (TL).

OPEN QUESTION: Who was the mother of Elias's children? Crest was born about twenty years before Sera Callum, and his elder sibling earlier still.

SUPERSEDED: The Crownward file gives Dorian's age as 61. Your ruling uses 59, which matches the timeline and the Audit Master.

The ledger and the Covenant of Dissent (TL, FR 40–44). In 2098, during a Crown advisory access period, Azrael found a ledger in the east wing archive. It ties the Empire's founding documents to a series of deliberate removals, which the Covenant of Purpose describes as God's order and the ledger describes as something else. It had sat there unmoved since 2085, because nobody was looking (FR 41). He took it to his father, who told him to put it back. Azrael kept it and went looking for its companion, the Covenant of Dissent. Elias wrote it in the same year, in the same hand, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on.

Dorian removed both documents the week Azrael was declared dead (FR 42). He told Azrael to put the ledger back because a document Azrael had read and returned would be one Dorian controlled. Destroying it would have told Azrael it mattered (FR 43).

[DESIGN NOTE: Use a family tree here, covering Elias, his unknown first wife, the removed heir, Crest, Dorian and Lyris, and Azrael and Judah, with the 2061 removal marked.]

Working questions

1. What exactly were the "deliberate removals" in the ledger: people, populations, records, or all three?

2. What does the Covenant of Dissent argue, in a sentence Elias could have preached? Why did he write it: doubt, insurance, vanity, or something else?
3. What did the removed heir know or do that made removal necessary in 2061? FR 35–38 cover how it happened and why Dorian was spared, but not why the heir had to go.
4. Who was Elias's first wife, and how does the Empire's official history treat her?
5. Where did Sera Callum come from, if not a "Northern Dominion"?
6. What does the Restoration Act's preamble say?
7. How do schools in Pacific teach the Partition, and how does that differ from what Pacific grandmothers say at home?
8. What did Celeste's grandmother lose when the signs changed? Who was she before the Fall?
9. Which lines from the 2033 sermon does every schoolchild know by heart?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part VII. The Covenant Empire: government and institutions

The Empire is run by three constitutional bodies: the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast. That arrangement is the Triune Rule of 2051 (TL). Underneath them sit twelve Dominions, each under a Governor-Prelate, along with a Registry that holds everyone's paper and a Vowed order that watches everyone's daughters. This part covers how those pieces fit together and where each one shows up in the book.

VII.1 The Triune Rule

In 2051 the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast were made the three governing bodies of the Empire. What had worked informally since 2043 became constitutional, and the Broadcast stopped being a network of Coalition media companies and became a branch of government (TL).

The three bodies split the Covenant Trials between them. The Temple runs Phase One and the Crown runs Phase Two. Endurance belongs to the terrain. The Covenant Score is weighted 30 percent Temple, 30 percent Crown and 40 percent Broadcast (TR). The Broadcast's share is never disclosed, because the public would be angry to learn that a broadcaster outweighs the Church in choosing the Empire's most powerful woman (TR).

[DESIGN NOTE: Org chart here: the Crown, the Temple and the Broadcast across the top, with the Governor-Prelates, the Registry, the Vowed and the Covenant Court beneath them.]

VII.2 The Crown and the House of Vane

Every Emperor is a descendant of Elias Vane, who founded the House of Vane in 2054 (TL). The Temple teaches that God chose Elias to restore the nation and that the Vane bloodline carries that anointing forward. The family's status is theological, not just political (CR).

Ruler	Years	How he held power	Source
Elias Vane	First Elector 2043, Emperor 2054–2061	Belief. A preacher who made people want what he wanted.	TL, AM
Crest Vane	2062–2085	Procedure: quotas, designations, criminal categories and the Trials	TL
Dorian Vane	2085 to now. 59 in 2104.	Performance. He brought back the spectacle and made the Trials the year's biggest event.	TL, Ruling
Judah Elijah Vane	Crown Heir, 25 in 2104	Not yet. Raised by the Temple as much as by his parents.	TL

Succession runs by survivorship and the absence of any other recognized claimant (FR 39). Crest inherited after his elder sibling was removed in 2061. Dorian, that sibling's son, inherited after Crest died (FR 35, 39). When Azrael was declared dead in 2100, the line passed to Judah (TL).

SUPERSEDED: The Crownward file calls Crest Dorian's father. Under FR 35, Crest is Dorian's uncle.

The Crown Heir's marriage is a matter of state. Dorian has pushed Judah toward an Anointed Wife since Judah turned 23, because an unmarried heir is an heir whose loyalties are still unwritten (CR). Elite men usually marry between 25 and 35. The Trials exist partly because of Judah's reluctance, to make the choice feel like an honor instead of pressure (MEN). Young members of the House take part in "Crown advisory access periods," which is how Azrael got legitimate access to the east wing archive (TL, FR 41).

Lyris Vane is 58. She's the Empress and the most sophisticated political operator in the Empire, and she's spent thirty years performing perfect Anointed Wifehood while running the Crownward's domestic and diplomatic machinery. She lobbied through Dorian for a decade to shape the Anointed Wife's legal protections, and she framed every gain as his gift (CR). She came from Mountain Dominion (WR). (Volume Two, Lyris.)

VII.3 The Crownward

The Crownward is the capital, built over Washington, D.C. and formally established in 2043. Elias chose to occupy the old capital instead of moving it, because you don't abandon the seat of the thing you claim to restore (CR). Most people in 2104 have never seen a photograph of Washington (CR).

The Potomac is now the Covenant River, and it divides the city (CR).

- **The Sovereign Side (west bank)** is where power lives: white stone, dark iron and formal rows of magnolias. The Crown Palace sits at its highest point. The Temple Sanctum stands at a right angle to it, joined by a covered walkway called the Covenant Bridge. The Broadcast Citadel sits on the northern edge, placed so its cameras can see the Palace and the Sanctum at once. Sovereign Boulevard runs half a mile from the Palace gates to the river, lined with Broadcast screens that show the Covenant Scores during Trial season. Covenant Row runs parallel to it and holds the twelve Covenant Houses, one per Dominion.
- **The Administrative Side (east bank)** is where the Empire does its actual work. It holds the Covenant Court's offices, the Crown's administrative apparatus, staff housing, the Vowed training facilities, the registration bureaus and the Registry. It also has market streets, Temple-adjacent schools and small restaurants serving food from across the Dominions.
- **Three bridges** cross the river. The Sovereign Bridge is the widest and appears on the currency. The Covenant Bridge, the river one, is narrower and used by staff. The Grace Bridge is the oldest, never fully renovated, and has blind spots in Broadcast coverage, so it's where people go when they don't want to be filmed.

RESEARCH: In the real city, central Washington sits on the Potomac's east bank, and the west bank is Arlington, Virginia. Read literally, the Sovereign Side stands where Arlington National Cemetery and the Pentagon are now.

POSSIBLE: Somebody in the Crownward knows the Crown Palace is built over the old national cemetery.

The Crownward has a rigid social order that nobody writes down and everybody enforces (CR). The House of Vane is at the top. Below it is the Anointed Court, about forty families whose standing is measured by how close they live to the Palace, and who must attend quarterly audiences with the Emperor. Below them is the Administrative Class, the senior staff of the Crown, Temple and Broadcast, most of whose wives hold Stewardwife designation. The Crownward's daughters who enter the Trials are rarely the most celebrated candidates, and they're almost always the most dangerous (CR).

[DESIGN NOTE: Map needed here: the Covenant River, both banks, the three bridges, the Palace, the Sanctum, the Citadel, Sovereign Boulevard, Covenant Row and the Registry.]

VII.4 The Temple and the Vowed

The Temple is both a church and a branch of government. In Eden's world it shows up as ministers, Vowed women and doctrine. Its scripture is read from a book called the Book of Covenant (DR3), and the Temple Sanctum in the Crownward is its seat (CR).

Ministers. Senior Minister Bell is the model: a man who signs Binding certificates, sponsors Assessment candidates, and prays God will close every door not intended for a girl (DR3). The Temple High Prelates sit in the Anointed Court (CR).

The Vowed. These are women in Temple service, and they run most of the Empire's contact with women. A Vowed officer assesses every Aurem girl at eighteen (DOM). Vowed officers conduct the quarterly household assessments in Aurem's Commonwife households (MEN), run the Regional Assessments (TR), and observe, examine and interview the Covenant Daughters (TR). The Crownward Vowed are the Temple's elite. They're also the Empire's most efficient intelligence network. The Temple calls it spiritual discernment and the Crown uses it as surveillance, and it's never written down anywhere the Empire could confiscate it (CR). In Red Earth, Vowed officers attend school performances as "pastoral care" (DOM).

The Vowed designation can be left behind through marriage. Delphine's mother went from Vowed to Bonded Wife, and Hannah was Vowed before she became House Mother (TR, FR 30). Sera Callum was Vowed when Elias married her (TL). Girls train through a Vowed education program, which Hannah's daughter Naomi has one year left in (TL).

The Prelate. She heads the Crownward's Vowed. She's 67, has served three Emperors, and is the most institutionally knowledgeable person in the city about how power actually works. She assessed Judah's spiritual formation personally. In the first week of the Trial she'll reach a conclusion about Eden that she shares with no one, the Emperor included (CR). She anoints the Crown Heir's bride (CR). The files call her Prelate Naomi, but FR 33 renames her so Hannah's daughter can keep the name.

POSSIBLE: "Prelate Aurelia" is the working name until you choose one (FR, closing note).

VII.5 The Broadcast

The Broadcast is the Empire's state media and its third branch of government. Its Citadel stands in the Crownward (CR), and its studios, the ones where Trial scores are announced, sit in old Midtown Manhattan in Saint Meridian, the Empire's Broadcast

capital (DOM). It holds 40 percent of the Covenant Score. Its share includes "narrative priority decisions" by the Broadcast Director that shift weight toward the candidates it favors (TR). It edits the Civic Debates for Dominion release and builds a story around every candidate in real time (TR, CR). When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, it runs the "Eve narrative," which implies and never accuses (TR). See Part XI.

VII.6 Governor-Prelates and the Dominions

Each Dominion is governed by a Governor-Prelate, a single political and religious office (TL). Governor-Prelates choose each Dominion's Covenant Daughter from the top three of the Regional Assessment, and in practice they take whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers (TR). How much each one actually controls varies a lot (DOM).

- Gulf's first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months.
- Lone's has always been born in Texas and has more independence than the rest.
- Pacific's was personally appointed by Dorian.
- Ardenne's has mostly stopped trying to fix the marriage records from outside Ashford.

See Part X.

VII.7 The Registry, the law and the paperwork

The Registry, on the Administrative Side, holds every citizen's Imperial record: birth designations, marriage registrations, Covenant Scores, Designation results and death records. Only the Crown Palace is guarded more heavily. Whoever controls what the Registry says about you controls something more basic than law, faith or the Broadcast (CR). Eden will understand this before most people in the story (CR).

Imperial law is interpreted by the Covenant Court. It keeps offices on the Administrative Side and secondary chambers in Blessed Shore, where the law "gets interpreted, refined, and weaponized" (CR, DOM).

In daily life the law arrives as forms.

- Household forms demand an adult male authority. Celeste wrote "deceased" on the line, and the form came back with the word circled and a request for the next adult male (DR3).
- A woman reclassifying her household under her own registration has to prove the arrangement is permanent (TL).

- Moving between Dominions requires Crown authorization. It's technically available and practically difficult (MEN).
- Any Ungoverned citation disqualifies a woman from the Covenant Registry (TR).
- Deaths are registered within 48 hours in the Crownward and within 24 in Meridian (CR, DOM).

OPEN QUESTION: What does an Ungoverned citation actually do to a person beyond disqualifying her? Is it criminal record, designation, or both?

VII.8 Surveillance

Cameras and Broadcast screens are everywhere in the seat cities. The Covenant Houses are wired in every common area, entrance and garden, but not the bedrooms. Leaving bedrooms unwatched is a deliberate choice to give candidates the illusion of privacy, which keeps them manageable (CR). Pacific has more cameras per block than any other Dominion (DOM). Red Earth embeds its Vowed in community life (DOM).

Records can be flagged. Eden's file reads "Exceptional intellect. Monitor closely," later updated to "Selected for Trial. Monitor closely" (TL). Sera's file was flagged before she arrived (TL).

The gaps are just as much a part of the world: the Grace Bridge (CR), the hollows of Ardenne (DOM), the Sable desert (DOM), west Lone's distances (DOM), and Saint Meridian's density (DOM). Endurance in Mountain terrain runs mostly without cameras (TR).

VII.9 Men, labor and the economy

The Empire controls women through designation and men through structure. Men are told they're free, and the control sits in housing, careers and marriage approvals (MEN).

Class	Who they are	Marriage	Source
Common men	The labor and service class, registered to their Dominion	Expected by 21. Unmarried men past 22 stay in labor dormitories. They marry within their caste and region.	MEN

Class	Who they are	Marriage	Source
Bonded men	Mid-tier administrators and skilled professionals, steered by Crown labor allocation	Between 21 and 25, from Unbound and Commonwife-eligible women, with Crown approval of the match	MEN
Covenant men	Elite: Crown officers, Temple leadership, Broadcast directors, senior military	Between 25 and 35. Their wives are Anointed.	MEN
Conscript men	Common boys whose scores flag them. Officially they don't exist.	Crown approval required at the Covenant Man level, for life	MEN

A common boy whose Designation scores come back exceptional gets a visit from a Crown education officer within three months, offering a scholarship to the Imperial Education Track. The family can decline. Declining routes the boy to the worst labor assignments for the rest of his life. Accepting makes him Crown-adjacent for life (MEN). (Volume Two, Solomon.)

At 18, common men register a Covenant Declaration with the Crown: a public statement of loyalty and readiness for service and marriage. Elite men register theirs when they finish the Imperial Education Track (MEN). Every Dominion layers its own rites over it. See Part VIII.4.

Each Dominion has its own economy (DOM).

- Irongate: manufacturing
- Lone: oil and space infrastructure
- Mountain: classified operations, resource extraction and military capacity
- Gulf: tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage"
- Meridian: law and administration
- Vane: the Broadcast

INFERENCE: The forty percent of working-class jobs lost to automation during the Fracture Years never came back. That's what makes Imperial service look like opportunity to a common man.

Working questions

1. Who sits on the Trials Commission, and is it the same body as the TR file's "joint oversight committee"?
2. What does the Book of Covenant contain? Is it a full Bible, an edited one, or a separate collection with the Empire's own texts added?
3. What does it mean, legally, to be designated Ungoverned? What happens to a woman's children?
4. What does a Crown advisory access period involve, and who else in the House of Vane has had one?
5. How did Lyris, a woman from Mountain Dominion, become Dorian's wife? What did the Trials have to do with it, if anything?
6. What will the Prelate conclude about Eden in the first week, and what will she do with it?
7. What does a Stewardwife in the Administrative Class know that an Anointed Wife doesn't?
8. What can someone on the Grace Bridge do that they can't do anywhere else?
9. Who runs the Registry, and who has ever changed what it says about a person?
10. How does an Aurem common man get Crown authorization to move to another Dominion? How often is it actually granted?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part VIII. Doctrine and lived religion

The Temple's official religion fits in one line. Private religion lives in kitchens, back rooms, deserts and mountains, and it's different in every Dominion. This part covers what the Temple teaches, what texts it rests on, how it uses scripture, and what people actually practice that the Empire doesn't know about or has decided to tolerate.

VIII.1 What the Temple teaches

The official theology of marriage is the center of it: "the husband leads, the wife supports, the household reflects divine order in miniature." It's preached every week in every Temple, taught from the time children can read, and assumed by every law that governs women (CR). See Part IX.

The rest of the official teaching comes through in what the files show the Temple saying.

- **The Vane anointing.** The Temple teaches that God chose Elias to restore the nation and that the Vane bloodline carries divine sanction (CR). Elias was canonized within a year of his death, "not quite sainthood but close enough" (TL).
- **The House judges fairly.** Bell tells Celeste "The House always judges fairly," and Celeste answers "The House calls whom it calls" (DR3). Before scores are revealed, Bell speaks about "divine order, talent as stewardship, and elevation as burden." He closes with "May every daughter receive with grace the portion appointed to her" (DR3).
- **The House virtues.** The banners in the Aurelia Temple atrium read obedience, discernment, modesty, stewardship and endurance (DR3).
- **Selection as revelation.** The Broadcast frames the Trials as a revelation and never as a competition, using words like anointing, covenant, calling, worthy and chosen. A competition can be rigged, while a revelation can't be (TR).
- **Being Bound as service.** "Every girl in Aurem wanted to be Bound. It was the only way they knew how to serve" (DR3). Covenant Candidacy is "the closest thing a woman could get to godliness" (DR3).

VIII.2 The founding texts

The sermon, *Thy Kingdom Come* (2033). Six hours long, preached by Elias Vane at The Gathering House. Since 2061 it has been required curriculum in every Dominion school (TL). It's named for the line of the Lord's Prayer that the Empire was built on. The novel takes its title from the same words.

INTERPRETATION: The old Companion reads the sermon as a familiar prayer taken literally in public for the first time, and that reading is useful. Nobody in the stadium heard a coup. They heard their own prayer said aloud by a man who wasn't embarrassed by it (AM).

The Covenant of Purpose. A founding document of the Empire. It describes a series of deliberate removals as God's order, and the east wing ledger describes the same removals as something else (TL). Celeste can recite it (AM, Celeste dossier).

The Covenant of Dissent. Written by Elias in the same hand and the same year as the Empire's founding, as the theological counter-argument to everything the Empire was built on. It was catalogued in library holdings until 2100, when it disappeared the same week as the ledger (TL). Judah has been looking for it since before his brother's exile (TL).

The Book of Covenant. The book Bell reads from at the Assessment. It includes Proverbs 31:29, "Many daughters have done virtuously, but thou excellest them all," in King James wording (DR3).

OPEN QUESTION: Is the Book of Covenant the full Protestant Bible, an abridged edition (see Volume I, Part V on the 1807 Slave Bible), or scripture bound together with the Empire's own founding texts?

VIII.3 Scripture in the Empire's hands

Draft Three shows the method directly. The Assessment's doctrine section turns scripture into House policy (DR3).

Passage	What the Assessment made of it
"Honor thy father and thy mother" (Exodus 20:12)	A question about reporting an Unbound woman who housed her children without male authority
The widow's oil (2 Kings 4)	An argument for household rationing
Esther's crown	Proof that a woman could influence government, "so long as she was beautiful, obedient, and prepared to die for the privilege"
Proverbs 31	The verse printed on the first page of the Assessment and read aloud before the scores

Eden's own read on this: "Facts might earn professional placement. Knowing which facts the House needed her to believe could carry her farther" (DR3).

Your Writing Rules ask that biblical truth in the narration be accurate and that the Empire's distortions be deliberate (WR 38–42). The research behind that line lives in Parts I–V. The household code (Ephesians 5) entry is already drafted in the calibration doc.

VIII.4 Lived religion: what people actually practice

In every Dominion, people do things around the official rites that the Empire either doesn't know about, tolerates because stopping them would cost too much, or eventually approves because it already lost (DOM, MEN).

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Aurem	The Salt Ceremony	The bride's mother or grandmother washes her hands in salt water the night before her Binding and tells her the truth about marriage	Doesn't know it exists
Aurem	The old way of burial	Three days, family-led, no Empire officiant: the Telling, the Feeding, the Release. Red clay packed down by family hands.	Doesn't know; the paperwork is filed anyway
Aurem	The Speaking	The night before a boy's Covenant Declaration, each man present tells him one true thing about being a man in Aurelia. The boy can't speak.	Unregulated
Aurem	Kitchens	Recipes that "looked like submission and tasted like memory." Women cook what they don't write down.	Never thought the kitchen was worth watching
Gulf	Music in worship	Live music at Bindings, against three ordinances, classed as "ceremonial expression within approved parameters"	Tolerated for tourism money
Gulf	The Last Free Night	The women of the family dance, drink and tell the bride the truth the night before her Binding	Never on paper
Gulf	The Procession	At 14, girls walk the boulevard in white, and the crowd turns it into a second line	Can't be stopped without a Broadcast incident

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Gulf	Funerals	Three days of open house, a second line to the grave, then the Quiet, one hour of complete silence	Approved in 2052
Ardenne	Hollow marriages	A community declaration and a broom jump	Records left incomplete
Ardenne	The First Winter Work and the Sitting	A real job in the community's survival at 13 or 14. Sitting with the dead through the night.	Unregulated
Meridian	Reading Circles	Officially Temple Bible studies. Actually a legal-literacy network for Stewardwives, running since 2069.	Doesn't know what they are
Meridian	The record	Before his Declaration, a father walks his son through the family's complete Imperial record	Within the rules
Vane	Ghost Marriages and the Ghost Declaration	Unions outside registration, and a boy's private statement of what he actually intends	Doesn't know they exist
Irongate	The Kitchen	The women's mutual aid network	Never mapped by the Vowed
Irongate	The Placement and the First Shift	Community assessments of a girl's work at 14 and a boy's first adult shift at 18	Unregulated
Irongate	Music	Blues and jazz, classed "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053	Officially suppressed, survives underground

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Heartland	The Anointing	The women wash and braid the bride's hair, each speaking a private word over her	"The most tender thing the Empire accidentally preserved"
Heartland	Planting	After a burial the community plants something that will come back	Approved in 2058
Red Earth	The Second Covenant	The morning after a Binding, a mother tells her daughter what the first covenant means and what she's allowed to keep for herself	Unrecorded, word for word across the Dominion
Red Earth	Score coaching	For twenty years mothers have taught high-scoring sons how much ability to show	Never documented
Red Earth	Sitting with the dead	Women sit with the body in shifts, and burial is at midday	Never understood, so never regulated
Lone	The Giving and the First Ride	The bride receives something of her grandmother's. A girl navigates a long distance alone.	Never acknowledged
Lone	Boots	The dead are buried with boots on	Approved without being understood
Mountain	The Witness Walk	A couple walks alone in the mountains before the ceremony	Unregulated
Mountain	The name to the mountain	A death prayer said once, with the name spoken to the mountain itself	Unregulated

Dominion	Practice	What it is	The Empire's position
Sable	Desert names	Every woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. A girl earns hers at the Finding.	Doesn't know they exist
Sable	The Desert Walk and fire burials	A couple's night alone in the desert. The name said once into a fire that's left to burn out.	Unregulated
Pacific	The Real Binding	A private ceremony with the promises the couple actually means	Unregistered
Pacific	Facing West	A boy faces the ocean at dawn, then turns back to the city. The dead are buried facing west.	Burial rules ignored until the Empire gave up in 2078

INFERENCE: Where the files don't say how the Empire treats a practice, the last column reads "Unregulated." The files give no sign the Empire has noticed those practices, but they never say so outright.

INTERPRETATION: A pattern runs through the table. The Empire approves what it's already lost (Gulf funerals, Heartland planting), and it tolerates what makes money (Gulf music). What women do in kitchens, at bedsides and the night before a wedding mostly goes unseen, because the Empire never thought those places were worth watching. Celeste's whole faith is built in that blind spot.

[DESIGN NOTE: This table could become a two-page spread grouped by rite of passage (marriage, coming of age, death) with the twelve Dominions as columns.]

VIII.5 Faith that isn't performance

The files are careful not to make every believer a dupe. Heartland faith is genuine, and real believers "have opinions about what faithfulness actually requires" (DOM). Heartland women questioning the Commonwife designation call it theological inquiry, and they mean it (DOM). Ruth Gideon "believes the Empire more than Eden does," and she's

sincere without being foolish (WR 26). Eden's own faith is real and "required more maintenance" than Maribel Vale's (DR3). Celeste is, by the old dossier's description, the most religious person in the book and the least Imperial (AM).

INTERPRETATION: The novel's religious line doesn't run between belief and unbelief. It runs between faith the Temple can use and faith that answers to something the Temple doesn't control.

Working questions

1. What does the Covenant of Purpose actually say? Write the passage about the removals in the Empire's own voice.
2. What does the Covenant of Dissent argue, and which line in it would get someone arrested today?
3. What is the Empire's official text of the Lord's Prayer? Has anything been cut, added or re-translated?
4. Which verses are carved over the doors of the Aurelia Temple and the Temple Sanctum?
5. What happens to a woman caught performing a Salt Ceremony, if anyone ever has been?
6. Has Eden attended a Salt Ceremony, or only heard about one? Has she seen an old-way burial?
7. What did the men tell Zion at his Speaking? Pick one line Eden will never hear.
8. Is there an Aurem equivalent of Meridian's Reading Circles or Irongate's Kitchen, a network of women that Celeste belongs to?
9. What hymns does the Temple approve, and what do people sing in the outer districts instead?
10. What does a Heartland woman's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation actually argue? This matters for Ruth.

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part IX. Women, marriage and the household order

Since the Restoration Act of 2041, a woman's citizenship has depended on her marital status, and marriage has been a legal and theological designation (TL). The Empire controls women by telling each one what she is and making that classification the frame

of her whole life. It's visible, documented and enforced through paperwork, ceremony and public record (MEN). This part lays out the designations, how a girl gets sorted into one, how the Binding works, and what the household looks like on paper.

IX.1 The designations

The files name these statuses for women.

Designation	What it is	Source
Anointed Wife	The elite tier. Wife of a Covenant man, and the status the Trials produce. It's attached to the marriage, so a widow loses it.	CR, MEN, FR 19
Stewardwife	Wife of the Administrative Class: elevated enough for status, constrained enough to be manageable. Aurelia has "Stewardwife districts."	CR, DOM
Bonded Wife	The tier Delphine's mother entered when she left the Vowed to marry. Probably the wife of a Bonded man (INFERENCE).	TR
Commonwife	A registration status, not a description (FR 1). Wife of a common man. Subject to quotas, the child quota and Temple review.	TL, MEN, FR 1
Vowed	Women in Temple service: assessors, officiants, observers. A woman can leave by marrying.	CR, TR, DOM
Unbound	Unmarried. Celeste has held it her whole life. "Difficult and surveilled."	TL
Ungoverned	Outside the system altogether. Women who chose exile over designation. Criminal since 2062.	TL, DOM

INFERENCE: Older notes describe a six-tier caste system for women. Leaving out Ungoverned, which sits outside the system, there are six designations above: Anointed, Stewardwife, Bonded, Commonwife, Vowed and Unbound.

OPEN QUESTION: Is that the six? If so, what's the official order, and where does Vowed rank?

The Widowed Covenant (CR) covers Anointed widows. Because the designation belongs to the marriage, a widow holds a temporary status for two years that keeps most of her protections. She's expected to remarry within the Anointed class, or she drops to Stewardwife. The senior Anointed Wives run a network so efficient that no widow has ever fallen below Stewardwife.

[DESIGN NOTE: A ladder diagram would show the designations, how a woman moves between them, and where each door locks.]

IX.2 Being sorted: Designation

Every girl is assessed and given an initial classification. In Aurem it happens at eighteen, by a Vowed officer, testing literacy, theological knowledge and "domestic aptitude." The result is a preliminary designation on the Unbound track or the elevated track. The elevated track means better education and a chance at Covenant Daughter consideration (DOM).

The age and method vary by Dominion (DOM).

Dominion	When and how
Aurem	At 18, assessed by a Vowed officer
Gulf	At 14, the Procession, "a declaration of loyalty and readiness for designation"
Ardenne	Standard Designation in Ashford. Hollow children are tested only when they can be brought in.
Meridian	Three-day sessions: theology, written reasoning, policy and "relational compliance"
Vane	At 16, the Broadcast Assessment, partly filmed
Irongate	At 14, the community Placement. At 18, Imperial Designation.
Heartland	At 13, the First Covenant, where her track is publicly set
Red Earth	At 18, two weeks in Temple spaces, Crown facilities and "domestic simulation environments"

Dominion	When and how
Lone	At 16 in Covenant Basin. The First Ride in the outer territories.
Mountain	At 16, with a physical assessment. Girls selected for classified Vowed service disappear from public life.
Sable	At 18 in Sable Reach. The Finding in outer communities.
Pacific	At 18. Every score is reviewed in the Crownward for signs of inherited resistance.

The Regional Assessment for the Covenant Trials is a separate process for women 18 to 25 on a Dominion's Covenant Registry. See Part XI. The placements on the Aurelia board in Draft Three show where an assessed girl can land: Administration, Education, Domestic Service, Housekeeping, Food Service, Binding Recommendation and Remedial Instruction (DR3). Strong doctrine scores can lead to Temple Administration. Strong household judgment can earn a Binding recommendation. Girls who test well everywhere can go on to professional placement (DR3).

IX.3 The Binding

The Binding is marriage as legal and theological designation (TL). In Aurem it's held in a Temple, witnessed by a Vowed officiant, and registered with the Crown and the Temple at the same time. The bride wears white and gold and takes a new surname hyphenated with her husband's. "Nobody asks if she consents. They ask if she is worthy. The correct answer is yes" (DOM). Ministers sign Binding certificates, adding their names beneath each husband's (DR3).

Every Dominion's version differs (DOM).

- **Meridian:** the most legally elaborate, with registration that can take three weeks.
- **Red Earth:** the most surveilled. Vowed officers witness every Binding, because the quota system needs real-time records.
- **Mountain:** Crown officers witness alongside Temple officiants.
- **Sable Reach:** Bindings happen at dawn.
- **Gulf:** keeps its music.

In the Crownward, a Commonwife Binding is a short registration at the Crown office, while an Administrative Class Binding is a dignified ceremony recorded for the Broadcast (CR).

The Imperial Binding for the Crown Heir has seven public stages (CR).

1. The Declaration
2. Covenant Week
3. The Anointing, a private ceremony on the sixth day in which the Prelate anoints the bride
4. The Binding Night
5. The Grand Binding, four hours in the Temple Sanctum
6. The Public Procession down Sovereign Boulevard
7. The Private Supper, five guests at most

The bride's vows are twice as long as the heir's. The Empire calls that theology. In practice it's a legal document spoken aloud in a sacred building (CR).

OPEN QUESTION: Does the hyphenated surname apply only in Aurem, or Empire-wide? Celeste never took a Binding name, so she's still a Parish (AM). Miriam's name after her Binding would be something like Parish-Osei.

IX.4 Commonwife marriage and the quotas

Commonwife marriage is how the Empire marries off the labor class. Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate in the Empire, because the Empire deliberately made marriage look like the highest honor available there (DOM). The quotas were introduced under Crest in 2062 (TL), after a pilot in Red Earth in 2058 (DOM). They're the reason Red Earth Bindings are documented in real time (DOM).

A Commonwife is expected to conceive within the Covenant timeline. In Aurem, a Vowed officer conducts quarterly household assessments in Commonwife homes. Two years without a pregnancy brings informal comments first and then Temple review (MEN, TL). (Volume Two, Leah.)

When a husband abandons his Commonwife, she can be reassigned to another man's household. That's what happened to Miriam after Thomas left (FR 0).

OPEN QUESTION: How does reassignment work? Who decides it, what is the woman's status during it, and why did Solomon keep the Osei name? FR 0 deliberately leaves these open.

IX.5 Anointed Wives and the Arrangement

The first Anointed marriage was Elias Vane's to Sera Callum in 2048. Every Trial since has tried to manufacture it again on camera (TL, AM). All thirty-nine Trials place Anointed wives, and the Crown contest is a layer on top. One woman goes to the heir. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder as designated, and nobody goes home unassigned (FR 19).

The elite husbands are chosen by the oversight committee and ranked by standing, not performance. A man can't reject the woman assigned to him, but he can decline the assignment altogether, which removes him from the ladder. It has happened twice (FR 28).

Among the Anointed Court, the official theology of male headship is mostly performance. The women run what they call the Arrangement. Wives manage the information, relationships and social intelligence that make their husbands' positions work, and they surface the right idea in private so their husbands can present it in public. They never take credit or contradict their husbands publicly. Their compensation is influence, access and the legal protections of the Anointed designation. New Anointed Wives learn it in their first year of marriage (CR). Lyris runs the whole network, which she inherited from the Anointed Wife who mentored her (CR). Celeste told Eden about the Arrangement before she ever left Aurem (CR).

INFERENCE: Ladies in Waiting, the Trial's third- and fourth-place finishers, stay in the Crownward in supporting roles (TR). Under FR 19 they would also be married into elite households. The two rules fit together if Ladies in Waiting are placed in Crownward households and serve the Anointed Wife on top of that.

IX.6 Unbound women and the household on paper

Unbound designation is "difficult and surveilled" (TL). An Unbound woman can head a household only through reclassification, and household paperwork still demands an adult male authority. Celeste's reclassification took six years, and Solomon's vocational form came back to the house until Zion, at eighteen, declared himself the authority (TL, DR3).

The Empire classifies children by household registration, not by parentage or appearance (FR 32). This rule applies Dominion-wide, beyond any one character. Hannah's daughter Naomi is eligible through Hannah's household and standing, whatever her father's status is (FR 31).

Home Instruction is an opportunity a minister can nominate a young woman for. Bell offered to nominate Leah "for Home Instruction the following year" as a consolation (DR3).

OPEN QUESTION: What is Home Instruction? Training for wives, a teaching role, or something else?

The Ungoverned are women who chose exile over designation. Their deepest roots are in the Ardenne hollows, where some communities have lived outside the system for two or three generations. The Empire calls them criminals, and the mountain people call them something closer to saints (DOM). Ungoverned crossings happen through the Sable desert (DOM). Lone interprets "Ungoverned" loosely and never files a full report (DOM). Saint Meridian has the largest population of Ungoverned sympathizers, people embedded in the system who leave gaps in it on purpose (DOM).

IX.7 What the households look like

POSSIBLE: The plainest way to keep the order straight while drafting is to picture the four households the book shows.

- Celeste's is Unbound, reclassified, with a young man on the authority line.
- Leah's is a Commonwife household under quarterly assessment.
- Hannah's is a former Vowed woman's household whose daughter is eligible through her mother.
- The Anointed Court households run on the Arrangement.

Each one is a different answer to the same law.

[DESIGN NOTE: Side-by-side comparison of those four households: who's on the paper, who actually decides, what's assessed, and what's hidden.]

Working questions

1. What are the six tiers officially called, and in what order? Can a woman move up, or only down?
2. What exactly is the Covenant timeline for conception, and what happens after Temple review? Is there a step beyond it?
3. How does Commonwife reassignment work, and who in Aurelia decides it?
4. Does the hyphenated Binding surname apply everywhere, or only in Aurem? What did Miriam's name become?

5. What is Home Instruction?
6. What can an Unbound woman legally own, sign or inherit?
7. What happens to a woman's designation if her husband is convicted of something, or declared Ungoverned?
8. Who are the two men who declined their elite assignments (FR 28), and what happened to them?
9. What do the senior Anointed Wives do for a Widowed Covenant woman in those two years?
10. What does an Aurem bride actually say when she's asked if she's worthy?
11. How does a girl in the Ardenne hollows end up Ungoverned instead of designated, and does anyone ever go back?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Part X. The Twelve Dominions

The Dominion Act of 2044 reorganized the states into twelve Dominions by region and economic function. The borders roughly follow the old state lines but not exactly, since some states were absorbed and some were split (TL). Each Dominion has a seat city renamed from an American city, its own Governor-Prelate, and a culture that's sometimes Imperial on the surface and sometimes all the way through. The rites of passage are collected in Part VIII.4. This part gives each Dominion's history, landscape, culture and record in the Trials.

Dominion	Seat (formerly)	Territory	In the Trials
Aurem	Aurelia (Atlanta)	Georgia, Alabama, Mississippi, Tennessee, South Carolina, North Carolina	15 Anointed Wives in 38 Trials, the most of any Dominion
Gulf	Port Seraphine (New Orleans)	Louisiana, the Mississippi Gulf Coast, Florida	Historically penalized for warmth
Ardenne	Ashford (Charleston, WV)	West Virginia, Virginia, Kentucky, Appalachia	Rarely produces Covenant Daughters
Meridian	Blessed Shore (Philadelphia)	Pennsylvania, Maryland, New Jersey, Delaware	Extremely prepared candidates

Dominion	Seat (formerly)	Territory	In the Trials
Vane	Saint Meridian (New York City)	New York and New England	The legacy Dominion, with the most Anointed Wives after Aurem
Irongate	Iron Benediction (Chicago)	Illinois, Indiana, Ohio, Michigan, Wisconsin	Almost always administrative daughters
Heartland	Providence Cross (Kansas City)	Missouri, Kansas, Iowa, Nebraska, Minnesota, the Dakotas	The most theologically fluent
Red Earth	Canaan's Gate (Oklahoma City)	Oklahoma, Arkansas, eastern Kansas, southwestern Missouri	Often scored mid-pack until it's too late
Lone	Covenant Basin (Houston)	Texas, New Mexico, western Louisiana	Pragmatic about the outcome
Mountain	Crestfall (Denver)	Colorado, Wyoming, Montana, Idaho, parts of Utah and Nevada	Has never produced an Anointed Wife
Sable	Sable Reach (Phoenix)	Arizona, Nevada, New Mexico, parts of Utah	"Two Sable women are worth five from anywhere else"
Pacific	Westhold (Los Angeles)	California, Oregon, parts of Nevada	Watched before they arrive

Source for the table and everything in this part: DOM, unless tagged otherwise.

INFERENCE: The overlaps (Mississippi, Kansas, Missouri, Louisiana, New Mexico, Nevada and Utah each show up in two Dominions) fit the timeline's "some states split."

OPEN QUESTION: Washington, Alaska and Hawaii don't appear in any Dominion. Are they inside Pacific, outside the Empire, or something else?

[DESIGN NOTE: Map needed here: the Twelve Dominions over the old state lines, with the seat cities and the Crownward marked.]

X.1 Aurem

Atlanta had Black wealth, Black culture, Black education and Black memory built so deep into the city that the Coalition couldn't flatten it without admitting what it was erasing. So the Empire dressed it up and called it restoration. The BeltLine became a ceremonial promenade lined with statues and Broadcast screens. Historic neighborhoods became Stewardwife districts, and Peachtree Street became Covenant Way. Magnolias were planted everywhere because they photograph well and rot slowly. Aurelia is the Empire's favorite mirror, Atlanta wearing somebody else's clothes, and the most surveilled and showcased territory in the Empire (TL).

It's humid from May through October. Storms leave the streets smelling of pine and wet concrete, and the red clay keeps bleeding through the paving. Black culture went deepest underground here and survived most stubbornly. Imperial hymns play on Covenant Way, and something else plays in the outer districts. Food is the main vessel of memory, and the Empire never thought the kitchen was dangerous enough to watch.

Aurem has the highest Commonwife rate and the most elaborate marriage ceremonies in the Empire, on purpose. It's the Empire's favorite Broadcast Dominion, with fifteen Anointed Wives across thirty-eight Trials. Its Covenant Daughter gets forty-seven seconds on Sovereign Boulevard in the Opening Procession, more than anyone else, and every girl in Aurem knows that number before she can read. An Aurem candidate is expected to win. The outer districts watch the scores with the intensity of people who never see their names on anything. Death is the place where "the Empire lost completely and still has no idea" (see VIII.4).

X.2 Gulf

New Orleans was never going to be easy. The first Governor-Prelate lasted fourteen months and reported the city "resistant to spiritual reorientation." The Empire settled for managing it. Port Seraphine is loyal enough for the Broadcast and layered enough underground that the Vowed have learned to look away. Hurricane season takes half the year, and the city is "built on water and spite." Gulf is the most culturally intact Dominion: music survived here, standing in plain sight, because tourism, rebranded as "cultural pilgrimage," earns too much to lose. Gulf candidates arrive fluent in being watched, and the scoring system has historically penalized them for warmth, which Crown advisors read as performance. A Gulf woman who knows the gap between what she shows and what she keeps is one of the most dangerous women in the room.

X.3 Ardenne

Appalachia was never fully inside America's idea of itself, and it isn't fully inside the Empire's. Ashford is the city the Empire keeps as proof that Ardenne is pacified, and everything past the tree line says otherwise. It has real winters, hollows that cut communities off from each other and from surveillance, and fog thick enough to hide the next house. The Ungoverned have their deepest roots here. Outer Ardenne children who get assessed score extraordinarily well, since children raised to solve real problems do well on problem-solving tests. Ardenne rarely sends a Covenant Daughter, and when it does she's usually from Ashford and quiet about the gap.

X.4 Meridian

The Empire took Philadelphia for its symbolism. The city that held the Declaration of Independence now holds the legal architecture of everything the Declaration claimed to prevent. Blessed Shore houses the Covenant Court's secondary chambers. Meridian absorbed Imperial culture more completely than almost anywhere, because its administrators trust process. Its underground is made of lawyers and bureaucrats filing precise challenges that go nowhere and documenting them for a future someone is preparing. Stewardwives here are expert readers of Binding contracts, trained in Reading Circles. Meridian candidates know every rule and where the gaps are, which makes one who decides to move almost impossible to stop. Corinne Vale is from Blessed Shore (TR).

X.5 Vane

New York was the hardest cultural conquest and the one the Empire brags about most. It named the whole Dominion after its founding Emperor, which is both honor and leash. Saint Meridian is the Broadcast capital, and the studios that announce Trial scores sit in old Midtown. The skyline stayed, and everything underneath it changed. The city's density makes surveillance both total and porous, and it has the largest Ungoverned-sympathizer population of any seat city. Vane is the legacy Dominion. Some families have sent Covenant Daughters to three consecutive Trials, and high-scoring girls are prepared for candidacy from the time they can read. Calla Merritt is from Saint Meridian (TR).

X.6 Irongate

Chicago gave the Empire industry and political machinery, which it kept, and music, which it tried to dismantle. Blues and jazz were labeled "morally ambiguous musical forms" in 2053 and went underground. Iron Benediction is the manufacturing heart of the Empire. Irongate is the most class-divided Dominion, and its labor and administrative districts

might as well be different civilizations. The labor-district women run a mutual aid network called the Kitchen that the Vowed have never mapped. Covenant Daughters are almost always administrative daughters, because selection rewards polish and polish costs money. Nadia Orin is the exception, the most working-class Covenant Daughter in Trial history (TR).

X.7 Heartland

The Heartland didn't need conquering, because the Coalition had been building here for decades. Providence Cross is the most genuinely loyal seat city in the Empire. People sing the hymns because they mean them. That sincerity is the Empire's most valuable asset and one of its hardest to control, because real believers have opinions about what faithfulness requires. Some of the Empire's most serious theological debates happen here, including Heartland women's "theological inquiry" into the Commonwife designation. Heartland sends the most theologically fluent Covenant Daughters, for whom devotion is both credential and liability. Ruth Gideon is from Providence Cross (TR).

X.8 Red Earth

Oklahoma's history of land taken and people removed came before the Empire. Canaan's Gate is built over a city that survived the 1995 bombing, and the Empire likes that resilience story. Red Earth piloted the Commonwife quota in 2058, and its women have lived under the full version longest. It's the most visibly religious Dominion in its architecture and the most privately exhausted, with scripture on every building and the Vowed embedded as "pastoral care." Under the performance runs a language of small signals refined over decades. Red Earth candidates are the best in the Empire at performing compliance while thinking something else. Delia Cross is from Canaan's Gate. Her family was transferred there from Aurem when she was six, and she carries a grudge against the Dominion she left (TR).

X.9 Lone

Texas negotiated its surrender. The Empire got the territory and Texas kept the attitude. Covenant Basin runs on oil wealth and space infrastructure. Its Governor-Prelate is always Texas-born and has more independence than any other. The distances leave real gaps in the surveillance grid, so west Lone is managed through local Vowed officers. People here perform loyalty loudly and then do what they were going to do anyway, and outer-territory women have a practical autonomy that would get them flagged in Aurem. Lone treats the Trials like any other Imperial requirement. Vivienne Hale is from Covenant Basin (TR).

X.10 Mountain

The Empire wanted the mountains for what's inside them: minerals, military installations, elevation and secrecy. Crestfall is the face, and the mountains are the truth. The classified operations there are the Empire's least documented and most important work: surveillance technology, resource extraction, Temple expansion funding and military capacity. Crestfall women are the most physically capable in the Empire and among the most watched. Girls selected at Designation for classified Vowed service disappear from public life. Mountain has never produced an Anointed Wife. Endurance was held in Mountain terrain for Trials 1 through 31, moved to a controlled facility for 32 through 38, and returned to the mountains for the 39th without explanation. Petra Solano is from Crestfall (TR). Azrael is hidden in Mountain Dominion, in a community whose patriarch owes the Vanes a debt (TL). Lyris is from Mountain too (WR).

X.11 Sable

The desert resists the Empire the way deserts resist everything, by not caring. Heat destroys equipment, sand gets into everything, and the distances defeat centralized monitoring. Sable Reach is the ornate Imperial city the Empire keeps as proof it can reach hard country. The desert beyond it is where Ungoverned crossings happen. The desert held civilizations long before the United States, and the Empire renamed the cities but not the land. Women in the outer communities carry plant and land knowledge the Empire has never catalogued. Every Sable woman has two names, one for the Empire and one for the house. Zara Voss is from Sable Reach, and her desert name is Tazaleh (TL, TR).

INTERPRETATION: Sable's two-name custom and Celeste's house name for Eden are the same instinct in two Dominions. Eden and Zara's name exchange in the middle of the book rests on it.

X.12 Pacific

Pacific carries the memory of resistance like scar tissue. The secession attempt and the two-year standoff produced a generation that remembers trying to leave, and their grandchildren know the story. The Empire watches Westhold harder than anywhere: more cameras per block, more loyalty programming, and a Governor-Prelate Dorian appointed personally, who performs warmth while administering iron. Old Los Angeles's creative industries adapted instead of dying, and people still make what they actually want and pass it through networks the Empire can't map. Every Pacific girl's Designation is reviewed in the Crownward for inherited resistance, and every Pacific Covenant Daughter arrives already flagged. Sera Montoya is from Westhold (TR).

Working questions

1. Where are Washington, Alaska and Hawaii?
2. How did Aurem get fifteen Anointed Wives? Which Trials were they, and does Aurelia remember their names?
3. What does the forty-seven seconds actually show, every year?
4. What is the real name of Aurelia's outer districts, and what do people in Sector Seven call their own streets?
5. What happened in the Gulf the year the Empire tried and failed to stop the music?
6. Who leads the Ungoverned in the Ardenne hollows, and what do they know about the Crownward?
7. What debt does the Mountain patriarch owe the Vanes, and from when?
8. What does each Dominion's Governor-Prelate want from the 39th Trial?
9. Which Dominion would Eden most fear being sent to, and why?
10. What do people in the other eleven Dominions think of Aurem, its forty-seven seconds and its fifteen Anointed Wives?

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions. Each Dominion profile could also get its own half-page of margin space.]

Part XI. The Covenant Trials as an institution

The Covenant Trials are a televised selection. Each Dominion sends one Covenant Daughter, and over about four months the Crown Heir's Anointed Wife is chosen from the twelve. The other eleven are married down the elite ladder (TR, FR 19, 26). The Empire presents the Trials as revelation, not competition, because "a competition can be rigged. A revelation cannot" (TR). This part covers how the Trials work in any year. What happens in the 39th Trial belongs to Volume Two.

XI.1 History

When	What	Source
2048	Elias Vane marries Sera Callum. The first Anointed marriage becomes the template.	TL

When	What	Source
2065	Crest introduces the Trials as "a celebration of the Empire's finest women." The first cycle is rough, and the ratings are extraordinary.	TL
22nd Trial	Ladies in Waiting introduced, to keep high performers in the Crownward instead of sending them home with influence nobody can manage	TR
Trials 1–31	Endurance held in Mountain terrain	DOM
2085	That year's Trial cancelled after Crest dies mid-cycle and Dorian's accession forces an Imperial transition. The twelve are sent home with their designations intact and no placements.	FR 34, 39
From 2085	Under Dorian the Trials become the most-watched event in the Empire's calendar	TL
Trials 32–38	Endurance moved to a controlled facility with continuous filming	TR, DOM
2104	The 39th Trial. Endurance returns to Mountain terrain without public explanation.	TR

INFERENCE: The Trials run every year. The first was in 2065, and with 2085 skipped, the 39th lands in 2104 (FR 39).

The 2085 cohort met while being assembled, prepared and measured against each other, and they're now scattered through their home Dominions. That shared history makes a network possible, but it doesn't activate before Book Two (FR 34). The 2085 cohort is the thing Hannah has never said out loud (FR 30). INFERENCE: She was one of the twelve. (Volume Two, Hannah.)

XI.2 Eligibility and nomination

Every Dominion keeps a Covenant Registry of women aged 18 to 25 who meet five requirements (TR).

- Unbound or elevated designation
- No prior marriage registration
- No Ungoverned citations

- Completion of the standard Imperial curriculum
- "Demonstrated covenantal aptitude," which means whatever the Governor-Prelate needs it to mean

Vowed officers, family members or community leaders can nominate a woman, or she can nominate herself. The Empire frames self-nomination as exceptional faith. In practice the process is built to exhaust anyone without institutional support, and most self-nominations fail for that reason alone (TR). In Aurem, self-nomination is "independent submission": a ten-dollar nonrefundable fee and a registration card printed in red instead of bordered in gold (DR3). Eden is the first Aurem candidate in the Trials' history to enter that way (TL).

Eligibility isn't entry. A House Mother can submit a name, but she isn't the only person who can (FR 27).

XI.3 The Regional Assessment and selection

Each Dominion runs a three-day Regional Assessment under senior Vowed officers, which produces a ranked list (TR, TL). In Aurem, results are posted in the Temple atrium on the third Monday of June at seven in the morning, and the top five are appointed to the Covenant. Their photographs hang in the atrium through the summer, and their families get the useful kind of formal review, the kind where unpaid levies disappear (DR3). Some sections, like Discernment and Spiritual Fitness, are graded by ministerial review, so a girl can know every answer and still fail for a lack of humility (DR3).

The Governor-Prelate chooses the Covenant Daughter from the top three. In practice he picks whoever the Crown has quietly signaled it prefers, then documents it as a choice from the top three regardless of the real ranking (TR).

XI.4 Arrival

The twelve arrive in the first week of summer, staggered across seven days so each arrival can be released as its own day of content. Each travels by Dominion transport with two Appointed Officers and her House Mother (TR). Each walks Sovereign Boulevard on camera. The walk is choreographed, and candidates are told what pace to keep, where to look and how to hold their hands (CR).

XI.5 The Covenant Houses

Twelve townhouses line Covenant Row, one per Dominion, close enough to walk to Sovereign Boulevard in under five minutes. Cameras cover every common area, entrance and garden, but not the bedrooms (CR). The candidates aren't sequestered. They're embedded in Crownward public life: Temple services, forums, the approved dining rooms, the Administrative Side markets (CR).

Each House has permanent staff. In House Aurem those are the House Mother, the House Coordinator, the stylist and the Debate and Protocol Advisor (TL). A House hosts one Covenant Daughter per Trial, and House staff serve across many Trials. Hannah's "six Trials, twelve girls" counts her whole career across several Houses and posts (FR 26).

XI.6 The three phases

The Trials run in three phases. Each belongs to a different power and asks a different question. The three phases also line up with the novel's Genesis, Exodus and Revelation (TR).

Phase	Domain	The question	Components	Weight
One: the Covenant Examination (weeks 1–4)	The Temple (Genesis)	Who are you?	The Settling, the Doctrinal Assessment, the Theological Interview, the Public Testimony	30%
Two: the Governance Trials (weeks 5–10)	The Crown (Exodus)	How smart are you?	The Dominion Forum, the Civic Debates, the Anointed Evening, the Pairing Introduction	30%

Phase	Domain	The question	Components	Weight
Three: Endurance (three days)	The terrain (Revelation)	What are you willing to endure?	Coordinates to reach across three days, with no schedule, no handlers and no cameras after deployment	Feeds the Broadcast's 40%

Phase One. The Settling is presented as a grace period, and it's actually the most intensive assessment of all, because the Vowed watch everything. The Doctrinal Assessment is a six-hour written exam in the Temple Sanctum, set at each candidate's ceiling, so no two girls get the same questions. The Theological Interview is a conversation with a senior Vowed officer, who's told to pursue any rehearsed answer until she finds what's underneath it. The Public Testimony is a fifteen-minute statement of faith and purpose, broadcast live, and the first time the Empire hears each candidate speak unmediated. Candidates are given Vowed handlers to "ensure theological accuracy," and they can decline them (TR).

Phase Two. The Dominion Forum puts every remaining candidate in a room with an Empire-wide crisis and no assigned leader. The Civic Debates are three filmed debates on governance, theology and social policy, with the topics given an hour beforehand, and the Crown Heir moderates the social policy debate. The Anointed Evening is four hours with the Anointed Court in the Crown Palace, where the cameras can't follow into the side rooms. The Pairing Introduction is thirty minutes alone with the Heir, with a Crown advisor and a Vowed officer present and a camera outside the door. The room itself isn't recorded (TR). The Commission has been known to wire candidates before Pairing Introductions (TR).

Phase Three. Endurance tests what the Empire calls covenantal fortitude and the terrain calls survival. The Broadcast films the deployment and the final checkpoint. Everything in between is reconstructed afterward from the candidates' accounts and is always incomplete (TR).

SUPERSEDED: The original Trials file used four phases: the Covenant Examination, the Governance Trials, the Public Season and the Declaration.

OPEN QUESTION: The original file also had candidates sign a confidentiality covenant before the Crown's phase, with immediate removal and a permanent Ungoverned citation for breaking it (TR-orig). Does that rule still exist?

XI.7 Scoring

The Covenant Score is a composite. The weights are never disclosed: Temple 30 percent, Crown 30 percent, Broadcast 40 percent. The Broadcast's share includes narrative-priority decisions by the Broadcast Director (TR). Scores update on the Sovereign Boulevard screens every evening at seven, in a ritual the Empire named the Evening Reckoning (TR).

Every Trial produces a Broadcast antagonist narrative, and it's assigned to the candidate who most threatens a comfortable outcome, not to the eventual winner. When a candidate's intelligence becomes the story instead of her compliance, the Broadcast calls it internally the Eve problem. The narrative implies and never accuses. It moves the Covenant Score without changing a single formal assessment, and it has worked every time it's been used (TR).

XI.8 The Declaration and its rules

After the Endurance rankings are confirmed, the Crown Heir names his Anointed Wife in a public ceremony on Sovereign Boulevard, broadcast live in all twelve Dominions (TR). The rules around that moment come from your Final Rulings.

- **The ranked winner.** The heir may choose any of the twelve. "Without deviation" describes the record, not a rule (FR 20).
- **What winning means.** Being the choice that costs the Crown nothing. The rankings tell the heir which selection is free. Deviation is permitted and expensive, and no heir has ever paid it (FR 21).
- **Refusal.** The recommendation stands by default once the Declaration window closes. Refusing is abstention, not resistance, and produces the same result as complying (FR 22).
- **Cancellation.** Impossible once the Trial is announced, except in a public dynastic emergency: the Heir's death or incapacity, or the Emperor's death forcing an immediate transition. A candidate's death doesn't downgrade a Trial (FR 23).
- **A candidate's death.** Her status goes back to her family, with no compensation and no punishment, as though the designation had never been made (FR 24).

- **Rejected candidates.** Married down as designated. The rejection follows them "not in the record, in the room" (FR 25).
- **Ladies in Waiting.** The third- and fourth-place Endurance finishers stay in the Crownward in supporting roles to the Anointed Wife and the Crown household (TR).

The Imperial Binding that follows is covered in Part IX.3.

XI.9 The Covenant Daughters of the 39th Trial

For reference. Their stories are in Volume Two, Part III.

Covenant Daughter	Dominion	From	Age
Eden Selah Osei	Aurem	Aurelia	21
Delphine Fontenot	Gulf	Port Seraphine	22
Maren Cole	Ardenne	Ashford	23
Corinne Vale	Meridian	Blessed Shore	22
Calla Merritt	Vane	Saint Meridian	21
Nadia Orin	Irongate	Iron Benediction	20
Ruth Gideon	Heartland	Providence Cross	22
Delia Cross	Red Earth	Canaan's Gate	24
Vivienne Hale	Lone	Covenant Basin	23
Petra Solano	Mountain	Crestfall	22
Zara Voss	Sable	Sable Reach	21
Sera Montoya	Pacific	Westhold	24

Source: TR, Ruling (Calla's surname).

Working questions

1. Who sits on the Trials Commission and the oversight committee, and are they the same body?
2. What do Ladies in Waiting actually do day to day, and who has held the title?
3. What were the Trials like in the 2060s and 2070s, before Dorian made them spectacle?

4. Who chose to bring Endurance back to Mountain terrain for the 39th, and why?
5. What does a Doctrinal Assessment question look like at Eden's ceiling? Write one.
6. What does a House Mother do across a career of many Trials? What happens to House staff when their girl loses?
7. What has happened to the women the Eve narrative was used on in earlier Trials?
8. Has a Covenant Daughter ever died before Petra? How did the Empire handle it?
9. What does the Broadcast's narrative-priority decision look like inside the Citadel, and who signs off on it?
10. What does a girl's family in Aurem get, specifically, when she's appointed to the Covenant?
11. What do the men assigned to the eleven know about their brides before the Declaration?
12. Does the confidentiality covenant still exist?

[DESIGN NOTE: The phase table could become a two-page structural diagram: three phases across, components beneath each, weights along the bottom, and the novel's three parts above.]

[DESIGN NOTE: A full-page handwriting workspace after these questions.]

Parts I–V. Scripture research (next)

The scripture parts get rewritten from the old Companion next, in the voice and label system set in the calibration doc. When the volume is assembled they go ahead of the world parts.

1. **Part I, Scripture as a library.** Canon, genres, translation and the reading method, rebuilt from the old expanded units. The household-code entry (Ephesians 5) is already drafted in the calibration doc and moves in here.
2. **Part II, The books.** A quick map of all sixty-six, the seven focused studies, and the four deep dives (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Deuteronomy). Every claim gets checked during the rewrite, since the spot check found errors.
3. **Part III, People of the text.**
4. **Part IV, Jesus, the kingdom and the Lord's Prayer.** The prayer entry gets corrected.
5. **Part V, Christianity and power.** This includes the American history section, which is new research: covenant theology, proslavery and abolitionist readings, the Slave Bible, the Black church tradition, Christian nationalism and Dominionism.